## *Theory: rules made to be broken (Feb 28 2026)*

- Music theory is not a set of rules you have to follow. But it's helpful to know some of the patterns that have shown up in music.for centuries!
    - "Music theory" is a description of harmony in the style of 18th century European composers.
        - There is a lot of music that doesn't fit this description, but still sounds good
        - The only "rule" if there is one: "**if it sounds good, it is good**."
    - **In theory we talk about "keys", "chords" and "scales"**
        - Keys are the tonal center of a piece, one for each key on the piano. There are 12 keys, each with seven different chords and scales that sound good around that center
        - Chords are combinations of notes that sound a certain way when played together
            - Major
            - Minor
            - Also diminished and augmented and extended
            - Scales are series of notes that sound good with a given chord
    - **The 7 chords and modes/scales derived from the C major scale**
        - Music in the key of C uses all the white notes starting with C (play **C major scale**).
        - Play the first, third and fifth note of the scale together (demonstrate counting scale steps), that's a C major chord, and it is the *I* chord in the key of C major.
        - Move up, make chords and scales for every scale step.
        - A major/minor pattern emerges

| chord | major/minor | mode | in key of C |
|---|---|---|---|
| I | **major** | ionian | C |
| ii | minor | dorian | Dm |
| iii | minor | phrygian | Em |
| IV | **major** | lydian | F |
| V | **major** | myxolydian | G7 |
| vi | minor | aeolian | Am |
| vii | diminished | locrian | Bdim |

        - The major chords in the key of C are C, F and G, the I, IV and V. These are often the heart of a song
        - Next page: Diatonic harmony demo: *Heart and Soul*


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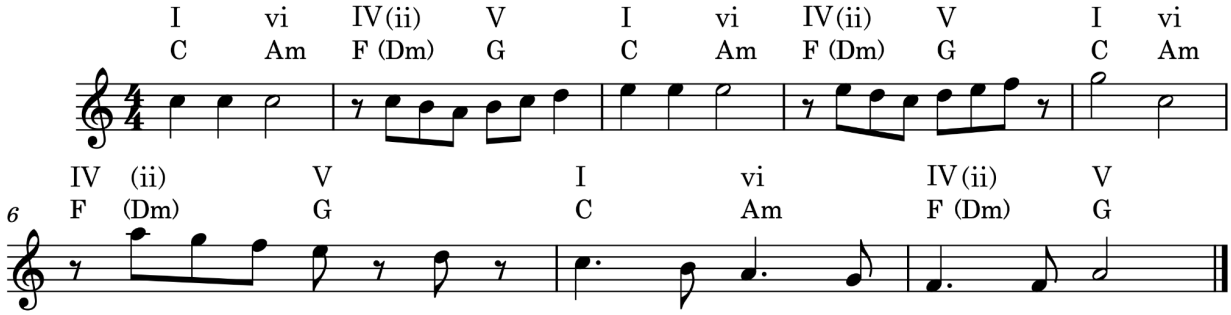
# Heart and Soul

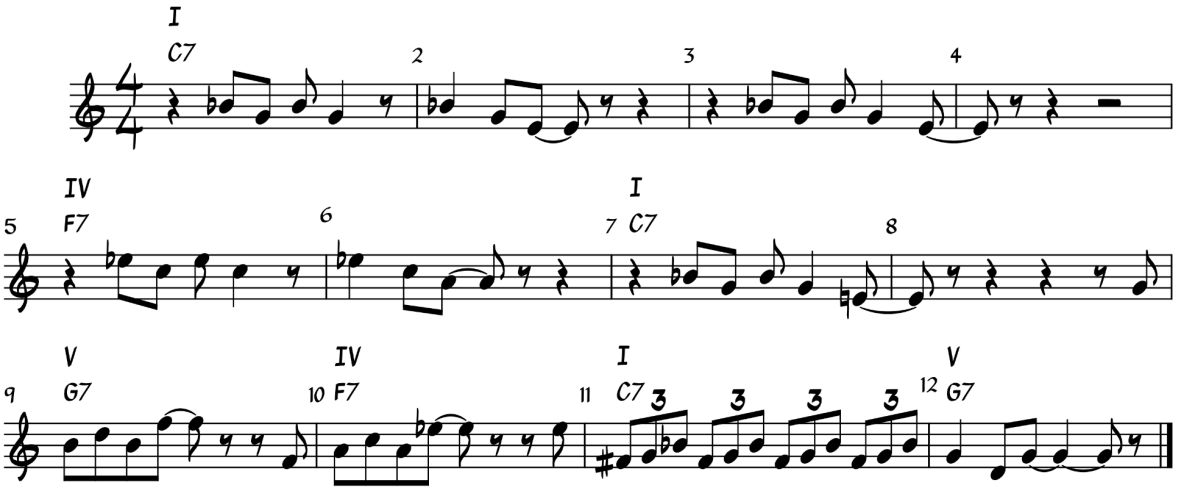



- Chords are I-vi-IV-V or I-iv-ii-V (discuss substitution)
- Melody plays only the notes of the C major scale.
- Try improvising the melody while somebody plays the chords. Do all the white keys work pretty much anywhere in the changes?

○ **Extended harmony with sevenths**

- With I-V-VI in C, we get Cmaj7, Fmaj7 and G7. Demo and discuss difference between Cmaj7 and G7
  - Does the G7 feel unresolved?
  - Does it lead you back to the center of the key, Cmaj7?
- In blues and rock we embrace the suspense of dominant sevenths for all the chords. So we get I7-IV7-V7. (blues harmony demo)

## Blues for TJ




- This breaks the rules! But does it sound ok?
- Demo “by the rules”without accidentals. Sounds ok but different?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